

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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2 Timothy 1:1

the life he has promised: See [Rom 4:13–17](#). This letter to Timothy celebrates Christ's resurrection ([2 Tim 2:8](#)) and the life that results from it ([1:10](#)) as the answer to the suffering and death of the godly ([3:12](#)). Paul's own life demonstrates this hope ([4:17–18](#)).

2 Timothy 1:1–2

See study note on 1 Tim 1:1–2.

2 Timothy 1:3

just as my ancestors did: See [Phil 3:5](#); cp. [Deut 6:4–9](#). • with a clear conscience: This might be in relation to heresy (see [2 Tim 2:17–18](#); see also [1 Tim 1:5](#)) or to Paul's previous legal self-defense (see [Acts 23:1](#); [24:14–16](#)).

2 Timothy 1:3–4

Thanksgiving and prayer are standard sections of Paul's letters (e.g., [Rom 1:8–12](#); [Col 1:3–14](#); contrast [Gal 1:6–10](#)).

2 Timothy 1:4

Paul begins urging Timothy to come to him (see study note on 1:5–14). • your tears: The two may have last parted when Paul was transferred to Rome under arrest (cp. [Acts 20:37–38](#); [21:12–14](#)).

2 Timothy 1:5

On Timothy's parentage, see [Acts 16:1–3](#); [1 Tim 1:2](#). • Faith means Christian faith, but Timothy's Jewish heritage through his grandmother and mother explains how he was rooted in Old Testament instruction ([2 Tim 3:14–15](#)). Their Christian faith was an example for him to follow.

2 Timothy 1:5–14

Paul gently but firmly summons Timothy to Rome (see also [4:9](#), [21](#); cp. [1 Tim 1:3–11](#), [12–17](#)). Suffering seemed certain if Timothy remained faithful, and Paul wanted to strengthen Timothy's resolve. • The allusions to the Spirit in [2 Tim 1:6–7](#) and [1:14](#) form an *inclusio* (literary bookends) around this section.

2 Timothy 1:6

fan into flames: The Spirit's work is not automatic—it must be cultivated (see [Eph 5:18–21](#); [1 Thes 5:19–20](#); cp. [Acts 4:31](#); [7:55](#); [13:9](#)). • The spiritual gift is the Holy Spirit's enablement for ministry (see [1 Cor 12:1–14:40](#); cp. [Acts 6:3](#), [5](#); [11:24](#)). • when I laid my hands on you: Paul and the elders ([1 Tim 4:14](#)) had ordained Timothy for ministry with the ceremonial laying on of hands.

2 Timothy 1:8

This verse summarizes the letter. Timothy would probably experience suffering ([2:3](#); [3:12](#); [4:5](#); see [Heb 13:23](#)) both in coming to Rome and in his subsequent ministry as Paul's successor.

2 Timothy 1:9–10

This passage underscores the importance of obedience ([1:8](#)) and strengthens Timothy for it (cp. [1 Tim 1:15](#); [2:5–6](#)). • God saved us . . . Christ Jesus, our Savior: God and Christ are described interchangeably in the role of Savior (see [1 Tim 1:1](#); [2:3–4](#)). • called us to live a holy life: Salvation and godliness are linked (see [1 Tim 3:14–16](#); [5:8](#); [Titus 2:11–14](#); [3:4–7](#); [Eph 2:10](#)). • not because we deserved it: We deserve condemnation (see [Rom 3:23–24](#); [5:6–11](#); [Eph 2:8–9](#); [Titus 3:5](#)). • that was his plan from before the beginning of time: See [Titus 1:2](#); [John 17:24](#); [Eph 1:4](#), [11](#); [1 Pet 1:20](#); [Rev 13:8](#). Salvation is completely removed from human merit and located exclusively in the gracious working of God.

2 Timothy 1:10

God's gift of grace has been made ... plain in history by Christ Jesus (see [Rom 16:26](#); [1 Pet 1:20](#)). • by the appearing: See study note on 1 Tim 6:14. • broke the power of death: See [1 Cor 15:26](#); [2 Thes 2:8](#); [Heb 2:14](#). • the way to life: See [2 Tim 1:1](#); [1 Cor 15:53-54](#); [Titus 1:2](#). • through the Good News: Salvation is provided by Christ, but its effects are mediated through proclamation of the Good News (see [Titus 1:2-3](#); [Rom 1:16-17](#); [10:14-15](#)).

2 Timothy 1:12

Paul had complete confidence as he faced his own death (see [4:17-18](#); [Rom 1:16](#); [2 Cor 4:8-9](#); [Phil 1:20](#)); it was an example for Timothy to follow (see [2 Tim 1:8](#)). • what I have entrusted to him (or *what has been entrusted to me*; literally *my deposit*): *My deposit* might be either the Good News that had been entrusted to Paul (see [1 Tim 6:20](#)) or Paul's life and ministry that he had committed to God.

2 Timothy 1:14

Timothy must guard the precious truth (literally *guard the good deposit*; see study notes on 1:12; 3:11) by faithfully proclaiming it and preventing false teachers from distorting it (see study note on 2:2; see also [1 Tim 6:20](#)).

2 Timothy 1:15

everyone . . . has deserted me: The desertion took place either in Rome or in the province of Asia when Paul was arrested. Paul might have seen this as another way his life followed the pattern of Christ's (see [Matt 26:31](#), [56](#)). • Phygelus and Hermogenes are otherwise unknown. The context ([2 Tim 1:11-14](#)) might imply that they were church leaders who sided with Paul's opponents.

2 Timothy 1:15-18

Using the examples of others, both negative and positive, Paul continues urging Timothy to be faithful and to come to Rome without fear.

2 Timothy 2:1

Timothy, my dear son (literally *Therefore you, my child*): In the Greek, *therefore* links this phrase back to [1:15-18](#) and the emphatic *you* is in contrast to those examples.

2 Timothy 2:1-13

Timothy is again told to be strong and to endure suffering along with Paul ([2:1-7](#); see [1:8](#)). Timothy's obedience should be motivated by reflecting on the Good News and on Paul's example ([2:8-13](#)).

2 Timothy 2:2

The many reliable witnesses would confirm the validity and veracity of Paul's teaching (see also [3:10-11](#)). • teach these truths (literally *entrust these things*): This verb is a cognate of *deposit* (see study notes on 1:12, 14). Timothy's own guarding of the deposit includes entrusting it to faithful people.

2 Timothy 2:4-7

In rapid-fire sequence, Paul quotes maxims about single-minded struggling and laboring.

2 Timothy 2:8

Jesus Christ, a descendant of King David, was raised from the dead: Cp. [Rom 1:3-4](#). Suffering with Christ should be viewed from the perspective of the resurrection to come.

2 Timothy 2:8-13

Paul's suffering ([1:12](#)) reflects the suffering of Jesus Christ and points to the cross and resurrection as the inner meaning of that Good News (see [1:8](#)). Paul's suffering, like Christ's, was instrumental in bringing salvation to others. Christ gives his approval to those who suffer and endure with him.

2 Timothy 2:9

like a criminal: Paul was identifying with Jesus' death ([2:11](#); [Phil 3:10–11](#)). • the word of God cannot be chained: Both Paul and the Good News would be victorious through the power of Christ's resurrection (see [2 Tim 4:17–18](#); see also [2 Cor 12:8–10](#); [Phil 1:12–14](#)).

2 Timothy 2:11

a trustworthy saying: See study notes on 1 Tim 1:15; 2:5–6.

2 Timothy 2:13

he remains faithful: This could mean that (1) he allows those who have stumbled an opportunity for repentance; (2) he faithfully judges unbelievers in accord with his unchanging will; (3) he himself is an example of faithfulness for his people to follow; and/or (4) he will faithfully accomplish his purposes in history, to save those who trust in him through the Good News ([1:12](#); [2:19](#)). See also [Rom 3:3–4](#); [1 Cor 10:13](#); [1 Jn 1:9](#).

2 Timothy 2:14–26

Timothy must insist on the teaching of [2:8–13](#) and steer clear of the teaching and conduct of the false teachers. The heresy was probably the same as in [1 Tim 6:20–21](#).

2 Timothy 2:15

who correctly explains (literally *who guides along a straight path*): The NLT relates this verse to right interpretation of the word of truth. Another possibility is that Timothy should keep to his purpose in teaching the word (see [1 Tim 1:4](#)) and not turn aside by engaging in the false teachers' controversies ([2 Tim 2:16](#)).

2 Timothy 2:17

Hymenaeus was earlier teamed with Alexander ([1 Tim 1:20](#)); both of them were still wreaking havoc ([2 Tim 4:14–15](#)). • Philetus was Hymenaeus's new accomplice.

2 Timothy 2:18

claiming that the resurrection of the dead has already occurred: Cp. [2 Thes 2:2](#). These false teachers might have twisted Paul's own teaching on the resurrection of the dead ([Rom 6:5](#); [Gal 2:20](#); [Eph 1:3](#); [2:6](#); [5:14](#); [Col 2:12](#); [3:1–4](#)) by teaching that they already fully participated in the heavenly life, and perhaps that physical resurrection would not occur. They could have concluded from this that one's conduct in the body (i.e., morality) was irrelevant, since their mortal bodies could have no impact on their eternal spirits. Or, they could have gone the other way, toward world-denying asceticism ([1 Tim 4:3](#); see [Col 2:8](#), [16–23](#)), with the idea that enjoyment of material things is inappropriate for resurrected, spiritual persons. These teachers might have understood from Jesus' teachings (see [Matt 19:10–12](#); [22:30](#)) that marriage should be prohibited ([1 Tim 4:3](#)). Their teachings on the Old Testament law ([1 Tim 1:7–11](#)) might have led to the promotion of certain taboos. Their teachings might have involved an overly aggressive promotion of equality (see [2 Tim 3:6](#); cp. [Gal 3:28](#); [1 Tim 2:11–15](#)) in the belief that the age to come was already here. Their teaching might have focused exclusively on resurrection power, which would contradict Paul's message of suffering and the cross (see [2 Tim 1:8](#), [12](#); [2:8–13](#); cp. [1 Cor 4:8–13](#); [2 Cor 12:8–10](#)). Whatever its exact form, Paul describes their teaching as "worthless, foolish talk" ([2 Tim 2:16](#)).

2 Timothy 2:19

Paul assures Timothy that the false teaching will not win (see [3:9](#)), and he reinforces the call to purity. • foundation stone: This metaphor emphasizes immunity to destruction ([Isa 28:16](#)) and might reflect a temple (see also [1 Tim 3:15](#); [1 Cor 3:11](#); [Eph 2:20](#); [1 Pet 2:4–7](#); [Rev 21:14](#)). • The Lord knows: This quotation alludes to [Num 16:5](#). • All who belong to the Lord must turn away from evil: See [Isa 52:11](#); cp. [Num 16:26–27](#); [Lev 24:16](#); [Ps 6:8](#).

2 Timothy 2:20–21

Building on [2:19](#), Paul uses imagery about the utensils in a wealthy home (see [Rom 9:21](#)). Within God's household one should endeavor to be like a

utensil that is cherished rather than one that is treated with contempt.

2 Timothy 2:22

those who call on the Lord: Cp. [Ps 99:6](#); [Joel 2:32](#); [Acts 2:21](#); [9:14](#), [21](#); [22:16](#); [Rom 10:12-13](#); [1 Cor 1:2](#). • with pure hearts: Cp. [1 Tim 1:5](#).

2 Timothy 2:24

A servant of the Lord: See [Titus 1:1](#); cp. [Isa 42:1-2](#); [50:6](#); [53:7](#); [Matt 12:14-21](#). • be able to teach, and be patient: See [1 Tim 3:2-3](#); [Titus 3:2](#).

2 Timothy 2:25

Gently instruct: Cp. [1 Cor 4:21](#); [2 Cor 10:1](#); [1 Thes 5:14](#); [2 Thes 3:14-15](#); [Titus 3:10-11](#); [Jude 1:22-23](#).

2 Timothy 3:1-5

Paul describes what people will be like in the last days (see also [1 Tim 4:1-5](#); [2 Pet 2:1-22](#); [3:3](#); [Jude 1:18](#)), which had already begun ([2 Tim 3:5](#), [6-9](#)).

2 Timothy 3:1-4.8

Timothy must stay on course through difficult times ahead.

2 Timothy 3:5

People like that ([3:2-4](#)) had rejected sound teaching and cut themselves off from the power that could make them godly (see [1 Tim 1:5-11](#); [Col 2:16-23](#)).

2 Timothy 3:6-7

The effect of the false teachers on households and women is a consistent concern of the letters to Timothy and Titus ([Titus 1:11](#); see [1 Tim 2:11-15](#); [3:4-5](#); [5:14-15](#)). Whether or not the false teachers targeted women, they apparently were successful with some of them.

2 Timothy 3:8

Jannes and Jambres are, according to tradition, the names of the Egyptian sorcerers who opposed Moses (see [Exod 7:8-13](#); [8:18](#); [9:11](#)).

2 Timothy 3:11

Timothy was from Lystra, near Antioch and Iconium, so he knew all about what Paul had suffered (see [Acts 13:14](#), [45-51](#); [14:1-8](#), [19-22](#)), though he was recruited after these events ([Acts 16:1-3](#)). • the Lord rescued me: Paul could attest from his own life that the Lord would accomplish his purposes through his faithful servant (see [2 Tim 4:6-8](#), [17-18](#); [Ps 22:19-22](#); [34:19](#); [Dan 3:17-18](#); [2 Cor 1:8-10](#); [2 Pet 2:7-9](#)).

2 Timothy 3:14-15

from childhood: Timothy's Jewish grandmother and mother, Lois and Eunice (see [Acts 16:1-3](#)), provided his education in the Old Testament Scriptures (see [2 Tim 1:5](#)), and their lives reinforced their teaching. • The Old Testament Scriptures give the wisdom to receive ... Christ Jesus. In turn, Jesus Christ is needed to understand the Old Testament Scriptures fully.

2 Timothy 3:16

The fact that Scripture is inspired by God (literally *God-breathed*, breathed out by God's own speech; see also [Heb 4:12-13](#); [2 Pet 1:20-21](#)) does not negate the active involvement of the human authors. But it does affirm that God is fully responsible for his word. Scripture is true, reliable, authoritative, permanent, and powerful because it comes from God himself. Its message is coherent, and it is consistent in its testimony about Jesus Christ (see [Luke 24:25-27](#), [44](#); [John 5:39-40](#); [Acts 3:24](#); [1 Cor 15:3-4](#)). Thus it has the power to bring salvation and elicit faith. It must not be abused, as the false teachers had been doing ([2 Tim 4:2-4](#); [1 Tim 1:4-7](#); cp. [2 Pet 3:16](#)), but must be taught properly ([2 Tim 2:2](#), [15](#)). • As a consequence of inspiration, all Scripture is useful. Both the Old Testament and the New Testament are together our guide and teacher in life.

2 Timothy 3:16–17

These verses elaborate on [3:15](#) by explaining Scripture's effectiveness, its source, and the ways that it gives wisdom to live out our salvation. Paul was speaking of the Hebrew Scriptures (the Old Testament), but his statement can now apply to all Scripture, including the New Testament (see, e.g., [2 Pet 3:15–16](#)).

2 Timothy 3:17

Paul makes it clear that salvation ([3:15](#)) results in godliness (see [Gal 1:4](#); [5:16–26](#); [Eph 2:8–10](#)).

2 Timothy 4:1

judge the living and the dead: See [Matt 25:31–46](#); [Acts 10:42](#); [Rom 14:7–12](#); [Rev 20:11–15](#). • when he comes (literally *his epiphany*): See study note on 1 Tim 6:14; see also [2 Tim 1:10](#); [4:8](#); [Titus 2:11–13](#); [3:4](#).

2 Timothy 4:1–8

Timothy stood in the presence of God and was to work in view of Jesus' coming to judge and set up his Kingdom (see [1 Tim 5:21](#); [6:13–14](#)). Christ's appearing will bring cleansing ([2 Tim 2:19](#)), accountability ([3:8–9](#)), salvation, vindication, and reward ([4:8, 18](#)). See also [1 Cor 3:10–15](#); [4:4–5](#); [2 Cor 5:10](#).

2 Timothy 4:5

This final charge summarizes what has been said before ([1:6–14](#); [2:1–15](#), [24–26](#); [3:12](#)).

2 Timothy 4:5–8

Paul effectively hands the mantle of leadership to Timothy (cp. [Deut 31:7–8](#); [34:9](#); [2 Kgs 2:1–18](#)).

2 Timothy 4:6

Paul pictures his death as a drink offering that is poured out ... to God (see [Exod 29:40–41](#); [Lev 23:13](#); [Num 28:7](#); [Phil 2:17](#)); this offering participates in Christ's own sacrifice (see [Col 1:24](#); see also [Rom 12:1](#)).

2 Timothy 4:6–8

Paul's faithfulness, vindication, and reward are a model and a challenge to others—particularly Timothy—to follow Paul's example after he is gone.

2 Timothy 4:7

Paul had remained faithful to the trust that was committed to him (see study notes on 1:12; 1 Tim 6:20; cp. [Acts 20:24](#)). He had preserved the integrity of the Christian faith and wanted Timothy to follow his example (see [2 Tim 2:3–7](#); [1 Tim 1:18](#); [6:12](#); cp. [Rom 15:30–31](#); [1 Cor 9:25–27](#); [Heb 12:1](#); [Jude 1:3](#)).

2 Timothy 4:8

Only one thing remained for Paul: the victor's crown (see also [Jas 1:12](#); [1 Pet 5:4](#); [Rev 2:10](#); [3:11](#)). • If we live expecting that Christ is indeed coming again, we can eagerly look forward to his appearing (see [1 Tim 6:14](#)) to set up his kingdom ([2 Tim 4:1](#)). If we don't follow Christ's commands, we cannot look forward to his coming as Judge and King.

2 Timothy 4:9

Paul makes explicit his summons for Timothy to come to Rome (see [1:4](#)).

2 Timothy 4:10

Demas: See [Col 4:14](#); [Phlm 1:24](#). • deserted: See also [2 Tim 4:16–17](#); cp. [Ps 22:1](#); [Mark 15:34](#). • Loving the things of this life contrasts with the anticipation of Christ's glorious return ([2 Tim 4:8](#)). • Crescens is otherwise unknown; his and Titus's absence seems to have heightened Paul's isolation. • Titus was Paul's effective and reliable co-worker.

Perhaps he had gone to Dalmatia (northwest of modern-day Greece) on a mission for Paul.

2 Timothy 4:11

Luke, the author of Luke and Acts, accompanied Paul in his journeys at various times. It is often supposed that Luke was with Paul as his physician ([Col 4:14](#)). Luke was the only one of Paul's co-workers who was continuously present with him. Thus Paul wished for Timothy to come quickly. • Mark: Paul's assessment that he will be helpful to me tells a story of forgiveness and redemption (see [Acts 13:13](#); [15:36-40](#); see also [Col 4:10](#); [Phlm 1:24](#)).

2 Timothy 4:12

Tychicus was apparently a Greek (implied in [Col 4:7-8](#), [10-11](#)) from Asia Minor (see also [Acts 20:4](#); [Eph 6:21-22](#); [Col 4:7-8](#); [Titus 3:12](#)). He was possibly going to Ephesus to deliver the present letter and take over for Timothy (assuming that Timothy was in Ephesus; see study notes on 2 Tim 4:13, 19).

2 Timothy 4:13

Paul's arrest and transfer to Rome apparently did not allow him to gather his things. • the coat: Winter was coming ([4:21](#)). • Carpus might have been Paul's host in Troas. The reference to Troas implies that Timothy was still in Ephesus and would travel through Troas, a port town. • my books . . . my papers: These writings may have included Scriptures, personal notes, letters addressed to Paul, copies of Paul's own letters, and other Christian and Jewish materials.

2 Timothy 4:14

Alexander was a common name (cp. [Mark 15:21](#); [Acts 4:6](#); [19:33](#)). Alexander the coppersmith was probably the same person as in [1 Tim 1:20](#). • did me much harm: Apparently he did more than merely oppose Paul's teaching. Perhaps he had a hand in Paul's arrest.

2 Timothy 4:16

The first time I was brought before the judge: A Roman trial was divided between an initial, preliminary investigation and the trial proper. Paul was probably referring to the first of these. It could also refer to his first imprisonment in Rome ([Acts 28](#); see 2 Timothy Book Introduction, "Date of Writing"). • Everyone abandoned me: See study note on 2 Tim 4:10.

2 Timothy 4:17

so that I might preach the Good News: Paul had turned his defense in court into proclamation of the Good News—just as in his earlier experiences ([Acts 22:1-24:27](#); [26:1-29](#); see also [2 Tim 2:9-10](#); [Phil 1:12-14](#)). • for all the Gentiles to hear: Paul sensed that he had completed his task ([2 Tim 4:7-8](#)). The Old Testament specifically anticipates the conversion of the nations (e.g., [Ps 22:27-29](#)). • from certain death (literally *from the mouth of a lion*): The lion is often a metaphor for enemies (see [Pss 7:2](#); [35:17](#); cp. [Dan 6](#); [Heb 11:33](#)). Here, it might refer to literal lions in the amphitheater, to the emperor, to the false teachers, or to Satan ([1 Pet 5:8](#); cp. [Ps 22:21](#)).

2 Timothy 4:18

God would continue to strengthen Paul and keep him strong in the faith ([4:7](#)) to the end of his life (see [1:12](#)). • The Lord's heavenly Kingdom contrasts with the earthly kingdom that was about to pass judgment on Paul (see also [4:1](#); [1 Cor 15:48-49](#); [Heb 12:18-29](#)). • All glory . . . Amen: Paul's doxology in the face of execution expresses confidence that God's glory will be upheld (cp. [1 Tim 1:17](#); [6:15-16](#)). • to God (literally *to him*): The Greek suggests that this praise is ascribed to "the Lord" of the preceding sentence—namely, to Jesus (cp. [Titus 2:13](#)).

2 Timothy 4:19

Priscilla and Aquila had been in Ephesus ([Acts 18:26](#); [1 Cor 16:19](#)) and were probably there at this time. They had also lived in Rome ([Acts 18:2](#); [Rom 16:3](#)), where Paul currently was. This might imply that Timothy was still in Ephesus (see [1 Tim 1:3](#)). •

Paul appreciatively mentions Onesiphorus in [2 Tim 1:16](#) as having ministered to him in prison.

2 Timothy 4:19-21

As in several of Paul's epistles, the letter closes with greetings and final instructions (e.g., [Rom 16:1-23](#); [1 Cor 16:19-21](#); [2 Cor 13:12](#)).

2 Timothy 4:20

Erastus was a resident of Corinth ([Acts 19:22](#); [Rom 16:23](#)). Modern excavations have found an inscription at Corinth mentioning an Erastus who was the city treasurer; he was probably the same man. • Trophimus ([Acts 20:4](#); [21:29](#)) was an Ephesian associated with Tychicus ([2 Tim 4:12](#)).

2 Timothy 4:21

before winter: Paul was probably concerned there would be an extended delay if Timothy missed this chance to travel in the fall (see [1:4](#); [4:9](#)). Winter closed travel across the Adriatic Sea from November to March (see [Acts 27:12](#)). Paul might also have been concerned to receive his coat ([2 Tim 4:13](#)) for the unheated prison. Eubulus is not mentioned elsewhere in the New Testament, but he was obviously well known to Timothy. • Pudens was a name used in upper class families. • Eusebius and Irenaeus later identified Linus as the first bishop of Rome. • Claudia is not mentioned elsewhere in the New Testament. • brothers and sisters: Greek adelphoi, a generic term that refers to members of the same family, both male and female.

2 Timothy 4:22

The precise phrasing here is unique, perhaps to emphasize what had already been said in [1:6-8](#); [2:1](#) (cp. [Gal 6:18](#); [Phil 4:23](#); [Phlm 1:25](#)). • with all of you: This letter would be read publicly.